

Taking the Rite Turn

THE MARRIAGE MARKET IS FRAUGHT WITH DIFFICULTIES FOR A WORKING WOMAN. BUT HAPPY ENDINGS ARE POSSIBLE, WITH A LITTLE HELP FROM TECHNOLOGY.

I got married a few weeks ago. By Indian standards, it is late. By now I should have been a mum a couple of times over and worrying about homework. Instead, I concentrated on my career as a publisher. The pressure to "settle down" began in college with my grandmother. There were gentle suggestions, "Don't delay. It won't be easy finding a husband." Later, the pressure became worse. It had insidious ways of making its presence felt. One day while on a walk with nana, we met an old friend who by way of polite conversation, asked if I was settled. Before I could reply, nana said, "She has decided not to get married." (I was 25.) My parents supported me and said, "Let her finish her studies. Then she'll decide." I was relieved. My nani and mother may have married at the "right age," but I had good examples in my great-grandmothers who married at 27 and 28. One of them only after she returned from Goucher College, Baltimore, in 1907. Her husband was at Mumbai port waiting for the ship to dock with red roses. He had waited eight years.

The pressure intensified when I joined the workforce. I wasn't making "sufficient" progress in finding the right partner, so concerned adults started doing the needful. I dreaded those unexpected dinner invita-

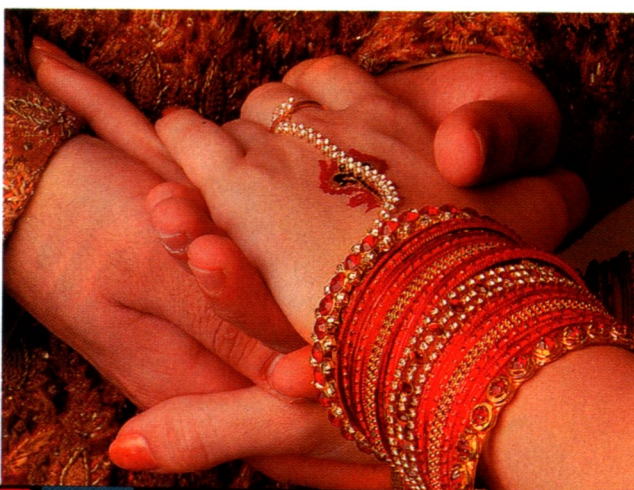
tions. Initially, I went with the flow. Slowly it dawned on me that this was a futile exercise. As I grew in my career, the silliest excuses were used by these prospectives to fob me off. Then my twin brother got married. Instead of congratulating me, I was being commiserated with. And then, when I crossed the

by strong women like you." I disliked their assumption that I was career-oriented and knew no other skills. I refused to speak about "homely" skills as there are more life skills than "qualifications for being a commodity in the marriage market".

But I don't regret exploring the arranged marriage route. From the well-settled

and I registered on a matrimonial website. He decided within two minutes of meeting me that I was going to be his wife. He proposed in less than 24 hours. I was horrified and said no. But he persisted until I said yes. I suppose it is appropriate for this modern day fairy tale that he turned out to be a "Cavalier" as he was knighted last year by the Italian President. Jacob too met many prospective brides and was familiar and sensitive to my situation.

It was a pleasant coincidence that we were from the same community and denomination, he is "well settled", we live within sneezing distance of our families and he is not intimidated by my career. It's a love marriage that was arranged by modern technology and is a partnership



88% IN LUDHIANA SAY THEIR MARRIAGES WERE ARRANGED WHILE 40% IN KOLKATA SAY IT WAS LOVE

dreaded age of 30, came the advice. The classic was, "You should always keep quiet and listen to what the man has to say." I gave up.

This was a hellish emotional roller-coaster ride and distracting for my career. I swore I wouldn't compromise. I hated that people passed judgement without getting to know me. I heard comments like, "You are a beautiful and competent girl, but men get intimidated

NRI to a "good match" in India, I saw and met the spectrum. The idea is to sort out all parameters—family, education, value systems, tastes, personalities etc. In India, a marriage is not between the bride and the groom but also between the families. It's a far more complicated procedure but it did not work for me.

Instead I found my husband on my own. Or rather, we found each other. Jacob

between equals. Having explored both routes, it is hard to conclude which one is better. I guess if we hadn't been through the arranged route umpteen times, we wouldn't have been able to assess each other swiftly. Yet, there is a sense of peace, that we took the decision to choose our partner ourselves.

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